the NRC, which it had championed between April and December 2019, on the political backburner.[68]

Prime Minister Modi drew a line under this in an election rally in Delhi's Ramlila Maidan on 22 December 2019 when he insisted: 'Those Muslims who were born on Indian soil should not be concerned by CAA and the NRC. They have nothing to do with these things.'[69] He said that there had been 'no discussion on the word NRC' within his government since it came to power in 2014.[70] Home Minister Amit Shah followed suit two days later with the same clarification and the government subsequently informed Parliament in February 2020 that there had been no decision to prepare an NRC at the national level.[71]

For Mookerjee, in 1952, the treatment of minorities in Pakistan was nothing less than a policy of 'squeezing out Hindus', which he considered an 'indirect aggression on India'.[72] This line of thinking eventually led to CAA.

It is no coincidence that Amit Shah, while defending the CAA in Parliament in December 2019, responded to the Opposition's questions by referring to the Nehru–Liaquat Pact of 1950 a number of times. He emphasised that India had honoured its obligations of equality and protection of minorities, as the Pact had envisaged, but that Pakistan—as an Islamic state with restrictions on equality for minorities—had not. This, he argued, was why CAA was necessary. On the question of why Muslims were left out from the ambit of the law, he argued that 'where there is an Islamic state, Muslims cannot be termed religious minorities'. He insisted that the law had nothing to do with the existing citizenship of Indian Muslims and they had nothing to fear. 'This is not a law for taking citizenship, this is a law for giving citizenship,' he said.[73]

A detailed examination of the legal debate on CAA is outside the scope of this book. The law has been challenged in the courts on several grounds. The point is that, leaving the National Population Register (NPR) aside, the BJP's move to enact CAA in 2020 was the outcome of a long-held article of belief: to correct what Hindu nationalists always saw as a historic wrong. The fundamental belief that underpinned CAA—the defence of religious minorities in